

THIS USED TO BE MY PLAYGROUND

gmax is Discreet's attempt at standardising a level design tool for the army of modders and mappers. It is freely downloadable and a developer only needs to supply an appropriate plugin for their game to allow a third-party to start creating custom content. id Software has released the gmax tempest plugin to allow fans and designers to create maps for *Quake III Arena*. We will use these tools to create a simple map with textures and a weapon as an introduction to using the gmax tool.

Before you get started, ensure that you have a complete install of *Quake III Arena*, Discreet's gmax, the gmax tempest plugin, Q3Radiant, which can be downloaded from www.q3radiant.com and more than 1 GB of free hard disk space. Next, follow these steps to configure the software involved:

- Locate the *Quake III Arena*\baseq3 directory and a file named pak0.pk3. Extract the contents of this file into the baseq3 sub-directory by using a program such as

WinZip. Install Q3Radiant into the *Quake III Arena*\Tools directory.

- Navigate to the gmax\gamepacks\tempest\textures directory, find the Common folder and copy its contents into the *Quake III Arena*\baseq3\textures directory. Next, go to the gmax\gamepacks\tempest directory and find the file named leveltest.map; copy this into the *Quake III Arena*\baseq3\maps directory.

- We now need to configure gmax tempest to use *Quake III Arena* resources. Start gmax tempest from within the gmax\gamepacks\tempest\ directory and enter the paths to the *Quake III Arena* executable and the *Quake III Arena*\Tools directory in the dialog box that appears when you first run the program. This dialog box can be later accessed via the menu bar under *Customize > Tempest Preferences*.

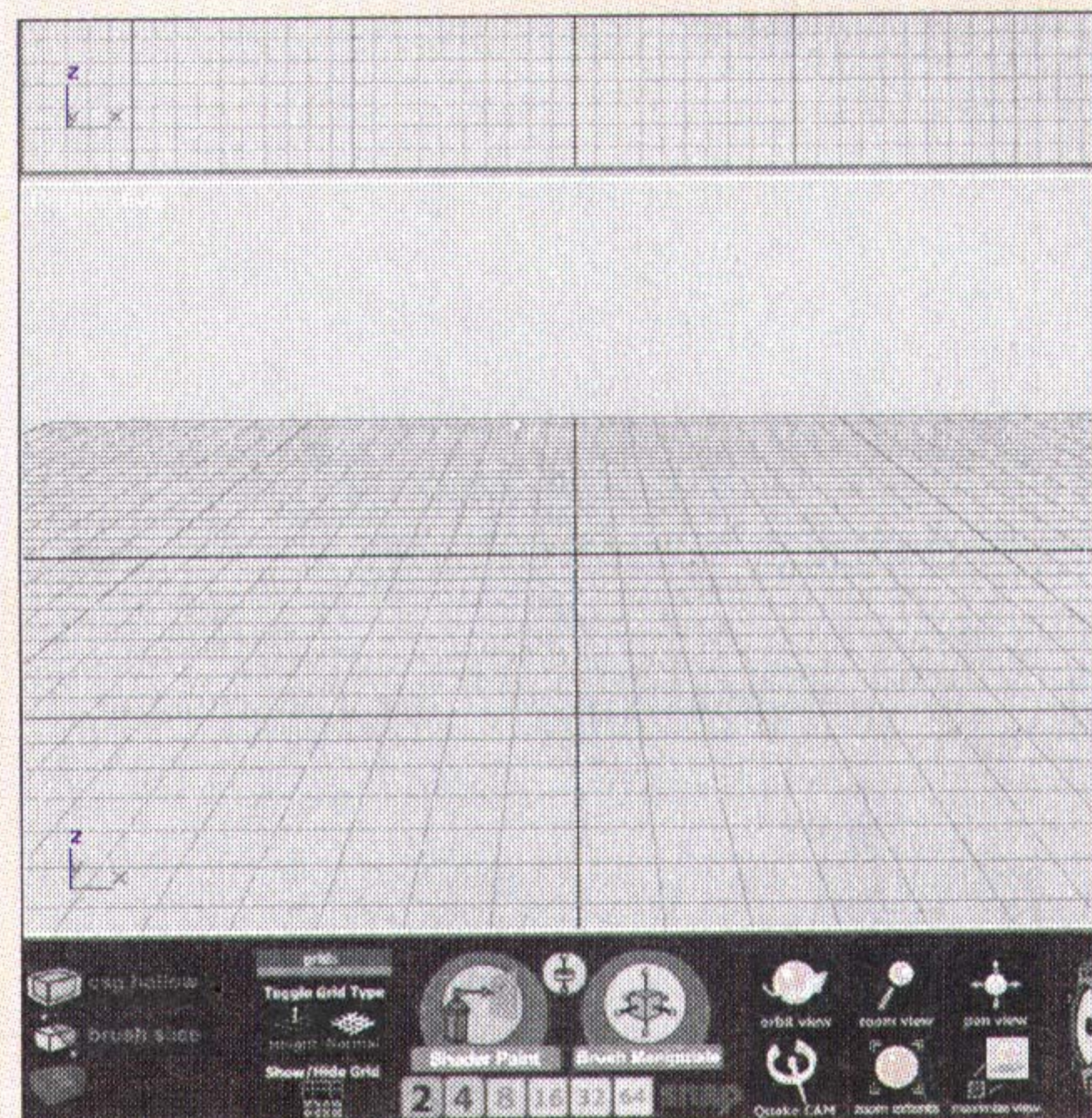
Now that both gmax and tempest are properly configured to use *Quake III Arena* resources, we can go ahead and create a map following these steps:



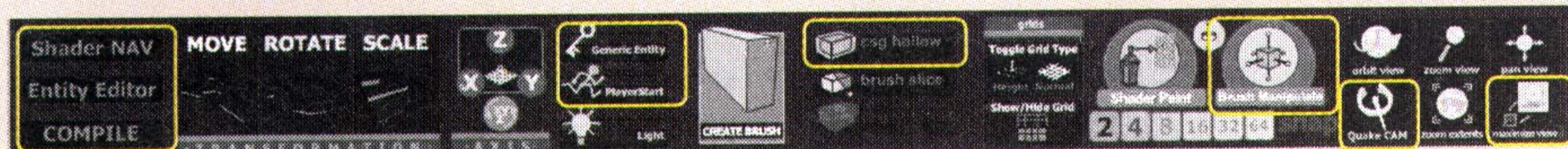
Start gmax tempest by navigating to the \gmax\gamepacks\ directory and then clicking on the 'tempest' icon.



Click inside the perspective viewport to make it active and then maximise this view by clicking the button in the lower left part of the Flash toolbar. What you see is the grid or the grid map. Zoom out to view the entire grid by using the middle mouse button. Activate the Height Grid by clicking on 'grid type'.



Seen here is the maximised perspective viewport



During the course of this workshop, you will come across some frequently used buttons, which can be found on the Flash toolbar of gmax. From left to right these are: Shader NAV, Entity Editor, Compile, Generic Entity, PlayerStart, csg hollow, Brush Manipulate, Quake CAM, maximize view

Built upon this foundation are set pieces that are immediately visible to the player. Animations breathe movement and pseudo life into polygonal characters, which use the rules set by the physics unit to move about levels or maps (the environment) within which the characters interact and interplay.

Amongst all these elements, the most visible and omnipresent is the level or

map, which is awarded the maximum polygon count from within the budget of a game. Not only does a level give form to a game, but it also extends its lifecycle, thanks to the concept of modding and mapping. A development studio will willingly give away the tools they used to create the game with the hope that enterprising men and women will create new content that will grant visibility to

the game and allow it to sell for a longer period of time. Most of the current games thus, come bundled with their own level-creation tools. The benefits of mapping go both ways—many a talented gamer has found him or herself working at a favoured development studio, thanks mainly to the quality of maps created by using these tools.

There are skill sets that are required to take up the job of level design. Familiarity with a 3D authoring tool such as 3ds max 5 or Maya is a given, since even proprietary tools bundled with games closely mirror the functionality of these industry standards. Formal training in the field of architecture is also a requisite, since creating levels is a mathematical task that requires knowledge of geometric shapes and how well they fit together. A level designer might also need to be a good texture artist, armed with working knowledge of tools such as Photoshop or Paint Shop Pro. However, don't be discouraged if you

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Game	Tool	Link
Half-Life	Valve Hammer Editor	www.valve-erc.com
Return to Castle Wolfenstein	Discreet's gmax	www.nibsworld.com/rtcw
Quake III Arena	Discreet's gmax	www.quake3world.com/editing
Unreal Tournament	Unreal Ed (built-in)	www.planetunreal.com/nick
Neverwinter Nights	Aurora Toolset (built-in)	http://nwwvault.ign.com
Elder Scrolls III: Morrowind	TES Construction Set (built-in)	www.elderscrolls.com
Warcraft III	World Editor (built-in)	http://maps.warcraftiii.net
Free textures	-none-	www.3dcave.com
Tutorials and articles	-none-	www.gamedev.net